

A CRUEL END
Distraught kin outside the Trauma Centre at Sikandra Rao, July 2

A LITANY OF LAPSES

A CRUSH OF RELIGIOUS FERVOUR AROUND A GODMAN AND A POORLY ORGANISED JAMBOREE END UP CLAIMING 123 INNOCENT LIVES

By **Prashant Srivastava in Hathras, UP**

IT **HAD BEEN 24 HOURS SINCE THE STAMPEDE AT A 'BHOLE BABA'** *satsang* in Hathras. Subhash Lal, 42, a security guard from Morena in Madhya Pradesh, had spent hours at the district hospital looking for his mother, who had attended the religious gathering. He finally found her, among the several lifeless bodies at the hospital.

Dayu Dayal, 65, of Kapoora village in Hathras, was still searching for his daughter and her two children outside that hospital on the night of June 3, saying he was unable to get any information about them, either from the administration or the hospital's information desk. An estimated 123 people, nearly all of them women and children, had fallen victim to the tragedy that unfolded on July 2 in Phulrai village in the Hathras district of Uttar Pradesh. More than 250,000 people had converged on a venue—an uneven, empty ground surrounded by paddy fields, adjacent to the Hathras-Etah stretch of NH91—that was meant to accommodate no more than 80,000. This surge of people was the reason cited for the tragedy in the preliminary report the Sikandra Rao sub-divisional magistrate (SDM) submitted to the district magistrate (DM), which INDIA TODAY accessed. Incidentally, the SDM, who had granted permission for the *satsang*, was himself present at the venue when the incident took place.

The crush of religious fervour is nothing new in India. Faith is a panacea for all ills for millions of Indians, and it was no different for the largely poor and lower middle class devotees of the baba, mostly from the Jatav and Valmiki sections of Dalits. Hathras itself is a Scheduled Caste reserved constituency that has been with the BJP for the past decade and which it won again even though it fielded a first-timer, Anoop Pradhan, this time. However, the baba's influence was not just limited to UP, but extended to a wider hinterland that included Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan and MP.

HOW THE TRAGEDY UNFOLDED

There had been a light drizzle that day, but the skies had cleared by noon, when the devotees began pouring in. The godman himself arrived around 1 pm, dressed in white kurta-pyjama, delivered an hour-long sermon to a rapturous audience, and departed around 2 pm, the *satsang* evidently a success. It was seconds later that all hell broke loose as eager devotees apparently rushed to collect a bit of the baba's '*charan raj*' or the dust from his feet, clambering on to the slippery embankment of the road from where his convoy had just left. The baba's security was allegedly trying to push this swarm of devotees away, when some lost their footing, taking with